



Goals for the TOEFL Speaking Section

*Earn a Higher Score with
Better Study Strategies*



TOEFL Speaking - Listen and Repeat

Grading Criteria	Scoring Dimensions	Possible Goals and Intentions
Repeat Accuracy	Correctly Repeated Words	- If you replaced a word, listen to the statement again and try to state it correctly. If you still replace the word, write two sentences with the word so you can get used to using it correctly. - Practice with the playback speed between 1.1x - 1.5x.
	Similarity to prompt	- When you struggle to repeat longer sentences, practice with simple statements first. Practice with a sentence that is just seven words or fewer. Slowly move up to eight, and so on, until you can repeat up to 15 words comfortably. - Listen to a movie, TED talk, or favorite YouTuber. Practice with long statements of up to 25 words. Try to repeat exactly as you heard without vocal fillers or repetitions.
Fluency	Speaking Rate	Read the sentence aloud. Try to say it one second faster than the recorded voice.
	Length of uninterrupted "runs"	Listen and repeat a 5-word sentence without pausing. If you achieve that goal, move on to six words, and so on.
	Number of pauses	Read the transcript of the sentence aloud, focusing on linking words together without taking a breath.
	Number of hesitations	Start immediately after the prompt is read and speak without pausing. Start with a 5-word sentence. After that, move on to a 6-word sentence, and so on. Try to get up to a 12-word sentence.
Intelligibility	Pronunciation	- Use a speech-to-text software to transcribe your recording. Check if it recognizes your pronunciation. Practice with words it has trouble identifying. - Select two or more words or phrases you would like to practice pronouncing. Write three sentences with these words. Read them aloud and check your pronunciation with a speech-to-text software.
	Rhythm	- Read the transcript aloud, focusing on linking words together. - Focus on bringing your intonation down at the end of every statement.
	Prosody	Identify words with three syllables or more. Check that you stress the right syllable and practice if necessary.



TOEFL Speaking - TAKE AN INTERVIEW

Grading Criteria	Scoring Dimensions	Possible Goals and Intentions
Organization	Discourse Coherence	• Include a personal example in this response to lengthen your response and add coherence. • Take a few seconds to plan out your response first. Decide what you will say first, second, and last. • If it sounds like you are rambling at any point, try the same response again by following a template and including an example with a beginning, middle, and end.
	Discourse Markers	• Include at least two discourse markers like 'for example' or 'additionally'. • Begin your response with a stock phrase like 'this is an interesting question'.
Language Use	Vocabulary Depth	• Pick two new words or phrases you would like to use in this response. Write a sentence with them and fit it into your response. • Avoid uttering a word or phrase you feel you use too often (e.g., 'good').
	Vocabulary Diversity	• Find synonyms for one or two common adjectives like 'good' or 'happy' and aim to use at least one in your response. • Respond as usual. Transcribe your response. Replace between 5-10 words and/or phrases and read your new transcript aloud.
	Grammatical Accuracy	• Stick to the simple present, present perfect, and past tense if you struggle with other tenses. • Review the popular grammatical tenses for each question and be sure to stick to them in your response. • Check what the subject will be and ensure that your verbs agree (e.g., "I").
	Grammatical Range	• Pick one conjunction to include and expand on at least one sentence (e.g., 'and', 'or', 'but'). • Write out one sentence with a grammatical form you find difficult. Include it in your response (e.g., a conditional sentence). • Start your response with an 'If...then' statement.
Fluency	Speaking Rate	• Pick two useful phrases you can link together in your response (e.g., "in my opinion", "I remember when"). • Write out your first sentence and last sentence before you start to speak. A clear beginning and end may help with your speed. • After you transcribe your response, read it aloud, aiming to reduce



		<i>the time by at least 5 seconds while sounding natural.</i> Count the number of words in your 45-second response. If it is less than 105 words, aim to increase by at least three words next time. Continue this process until you reach at least 105 words.
	Sustained Speech	- Aim to have five or fewer vocal fillers in your response. - Replace 'uh' and 'umm' with words like 'okay', 'well', or 'so'. - Plan to use two discourse markers to help deliver smooth transitions (e.g., 'to start', 'on the other hand').
	Pause Frequency	- Shadow a native speaker's response to the same question. Include one sentence from their response in your own and match their speech music. - After you finish recording and transcribing your response, read your transcript aloud, this time focusing on linking phrases together and chunking clauses. In other words, focus on your speech music. - Write out one short sentence you will include in your response and aim to say it in one breath.
	Repetitions	- Find synonyms for one or two common adjectives like 'good' or 'happy' and aim to use at least one. - Plan out your response. Think about what you are going to say first, second, and so on. Do NOT write everything down. This will help reduce the number of hesitations and repetitions.
Intelligibility	Pronunciation	- After you finish recording and transcribing your response, read your transcript aloud, this time focusing on words and phrases you have trouble pronouncing. Pick two words or phrases you would like to include next time. - Select two or more words or phrases you would like to practice pronouncing. Write one or two sentences with these words and include them in your response.
	Rhythm	- Shadow a native speaker's response to the same question. Include one sentence from their response in your own and match their speech music. - After you finish, read your transcript aloud, this time focusing on linking phrases and clauses together. In other words, focus on your speech music, pausing when a native speaker would.
	Prosody	After you transcribe your response, identify at least two words with three syllables or more. Check that you stress the right syllable and practice if necessary.

Source: [TOEFL iBT Technical Manual](#), published 10.09.2025

